doubt over it. When I talk about Jammu and Kashmir, Pakistan occupied Kashmir and Aksai Chin are included in it . . . This country's Parliament cannot be stopped from making any law on J&K.'[3] Shah's statement on Indian claims is consistent with Delhi's formal stand going back to the 1950s, but his abrasive tone probably provoked Beijing to immediately say: 'China is always opposed to India's inclusion of the Chinese territory [i.e. Ladakh] in the western sector of the China-India boundary into its administrative jurisdiction. Recently India has continued to undermine China's territorial sovereignty by unilaterally changing its domestic law. Such practice is unacceptable and will not come into force.'[4]

Well into the crisis in Ladakh, in September 2020, Beijing very publicly insisted that 'the China-India border LAC is very clear, [and] that is the LAC on November 7, 1959. China announced it in the 1950s, and the international community including India are also clear about it.'[5] That claim line includes all of Aksai Chin and territories up to the foothills of the mountains in Arunachal Pradesh. China first invoked the line back in 1959 as the basis for a mutual pullback of forces to stabilize the deteriorating military situation. Beijing followed up the September 2020 statement by repeating its opposition to the changes in Jammu and Kashmir: 'China doesn't recognize the so-called "Ladakh Union Territory" illegally set up by India and opposes infrastructure building aimed at military contention in disputed border areas.'[6] By going so public on its claims, and by its continued rejection of India's reorganization of Jammu and Kashmir, Beijing has indicated a firm position, from which it will be difficult to retreat. Delhi had rejected the 1959 proposal and is adamant on the reorganization of Jammu and Kashmir. If and when Indian and Chinese negotiators sit down to discuss a border settlement, they will have to find a way to deal with a new set of mutually contradictory and very public stands.

Beyond the border but related to it is the issue of Tibet. The Dalai Lama's advanced age is bringing Tibet once again into focus in India–China relations. Beijing has said it will find a new Dalai Lama from among Tibetans in Tibet. At times, the Dalai Lama has said that he might be the